U.S. Government Publishing Office
Publications Help Desk

Service Level Agreement and Escalation Matrix

Response and resolution commitments, measurement rules, escalation tiers, and after-hours procedure

Field	Value
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Training sample. All names, contact details, prices, timelines, and procedures in this document are fictional and were created for a Microsoft Copilot Studio demonstration. They do not represent actual GPO policy.

Document Control

This section records the revision history and the approval chain for this document. Changes to any procedural step, time target, fee, or contact require a new version number and approval by the document owner.

Version	Date	Author	Summary of change
1.0	April 1, 2024	P. Venkataraman	Initial service level agreement
2.0	October 1, 2025	P. Venkataraman	Added P4 tier; added clock stop rules; added after-hours procedure
2.2	March 16, 2026	M. Grant	Added substitute roster and monthly metric definitions
2.4	October 1, 2026	P. Venkataraman	Revised Tier 3 trigger; updated contact roster

1. Purpose and Parties

This Service Level Agreement (SLA) states what customers of the Publications Help Desk (PHD) can expect in response time, resolution time, and escalation handling, and how those commitments are measured. It is an internal service agreement between GPO Customer Services, which operates the help desk, and the agency publishing liaisons and GPO offices that use it. It is not a contract and creates no financial remedy; its purpose is to make service expectations explicit and measurable so that problems are visible and can be fixed.

The SLA covers every ticket logged in the PHD Service Portal. It does not cover production turnaround, which is governed by the Turnaround Matrix in the Job Catalog and Fee Schedule (GPO-PHD-006) and starts at proof approval, nor does it cover work performed by outside vendors, which is scheduled by Production Planning on a job by job basis.

2. Definitions

Term	Definition
Staffed hours	Monday through Friday, 7:30 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. Eastern Time, excluding Federal holidays. All targets in this SLA are measured in staffed hours or business days.
Business day	One calendar day that falls within staffed hours. A target of 1 business day received at 3:00 p.m. Tuesday is due 3:00 p.m. Wednesday.
Ticket	A record in the PHD Service Portal, numbered PHD-YYYY-NNNNNN, created by a customer or by a specialist on the customer's behalf.
First response	A substantive reply from a named specialist that confirms the ticket number, restates the request, states the priority, and gives the next expected update. The automated portal acknowledgment is not a first response.

Term	Definition
Resolution	The customer has what they asked for, or has been told clearly why it cannot be provided and what the alternative is. A ticket that is waiting on the customer is not unresolved for measurement purposes; see clock stops.
Clock stop	A period during which the response or resolution clock does not run, because the ticket is waiting on the customer, on an outside vendor, or on a decision from another GPO unit that has been formally requested.
Escalation	Moving a ticket to a higher tier so that a person with more authority or a different capability can act. Escalation is a normal part of the process, not a complaint.
Breach	A ticket that misses a first response or resolution target after clock stops are excluded.

3. Priority Framework

Priority is assigned by the help desk based on business impact. The customer's description of urgency is an input, not the determinant. A customer may ask for a priority review at any time; the reviewing specialist records the decision and the reason on the ticket.

Priority	Definition	Examples	First response	Resolution
P1 Critical	A Congressional, statutory, or public commitment date is at risk, or a job in production has stopped	Hearing print due tomorrow with a press fault; a regulation effective date that requires a printed notice; a public launch event	30 minutes	4 business hours
P2 High	A job is blocked and cannot proceed to the next stage without help desk action	A proof cannot be opened; a billing code is rejected; a shipment is missing	2 business hours	1 business day
P3 Normal	A routine request that does not block work	A question about a fee; help completing a PSR; a status inquiry	4 business hours	3 business days
P4 Low	An informational question with no dependent work	A style question; a request for documentation; a suggestion	1 business day	5 business days

Priority is about impact, not seniority

A request from a senior official is not automatically P1. A request from a new liaison about a hearing print due tomorrow is P1. Specialists are trained to ask two questions on every ticket: what happens if this is not resolved today, and who is affected.

4. Service Commitments by Request Category

The following table shows the default priority for each ticket category and the resulting targets. A specialist may raise or lower the priority from the default based on the impact questions in Section 3, and records the reason on the ticket.

Category	Default priority	First response	Resolution	Typical resolution path
Service question	P3	4 business hours	3 business days	Specialist answers from the knowledge library or consults Production Planning
PSR assistance	P3	4 business hours	3 business days	Specialist reviews the draft PSR with the liaison and corrects it
Status inquiry	P3	4 business hours	3 business days	Specialist reads the PSR status and next action and relays it
Production issue	P2	2 business hours	1 business day	Specialist escalates to Tier 2; Production Planning investigates and issues a plan
Deadline risk	P1	30 minutes	4 business hours	Specialist notifies Tier 2 immediately; a plan is issued and updates follow every 2 business hours
Accessibility	P3	4 business hours	3 business days	Specialist routes to the Accessibility Specialist for an answer or remediation estimate
Style and editorial	P4	1 business day	5 business days	Specialist answers from the Style Quick Reference or routes to the Editorial Standards Lead
Onboarding and access	P3	4 business hours	3 business days	Specialist creates or updates the portal account after verifying the designation
Referral	P4	1 business day	1 business day	Specialist provides the referral and closes the ticket as Referred

5. Measurement Rules

5.1 How the clocks run

- The first response clock starts when the ticket is created in the portal, regardless of channel. For tickets created by a specialist on the customer's behalf, it starts when the customer first contacted the help desk.
- The resolution clock starts at the same moment and runs until the ticket status is set to Resolved.
- Both clocks run only during staffed hours. A P3 ticket created at 4:30 p.m. Friday has a first response due by 10:30 a.m. the following Monday if Monday is not a holiday.
- Priority changes reset neither clock. A ticket raised from P3 to P1 keeps its original start time and immediately inherits the P1 targets.

5.2 Clock stops

The clocks stop when the specialist sets the ticket status to one of the following, and restart when the condition clears. Each clock stop must be recorded with a reason and the date and time it began.

Clock stop status	When it applies	Restart condition
Waiting on customer	The specialist has asked the customer a question or requested a file and cannot proceed without it	The customer replies or the file arrives
Waiting on vendor	An outside vendor is quoting or producing part of the job	The vendor delivers the quote or product
Waiting on GPO unit	A formal request has been made to another GPO unit and is documented on the ticket	The unit responds
Scheduled follow up	The customer has asked for action on a future date	The scheduled date arrives

5.3 What counts as a breach

A ticket breaches when a target passes without the required event, after excluding clock stops. Breaches are recorded automatically by the portal and reviewed weekly by the help desk supervisor. A breach is not a disciplinary event; it is a signal that a process, a capacity, or a piece of documentation needs attention.

6. Escalation Matrix

Escalation is triggered by the conditions below, not by customer request alone. A customer may always ask for escalation, and the specialist records the request; the specialist escalates when a trigger condition is met or when, in the specialist's judgment, the ticket needs a capability the specialist does not have.

Tier	Escalation point	Triggers	Expected action	Time to act
Tier 1	Help desk specialist on duty	All tickets start here	Own the ticket, respond, resolve or escalate	Per priority targets
Tier 2	Devin Okafor, Production Planning Lead	Production issue; rush decision; capacity question; any ticket that has missed its first response target; any P1 at creation	Investigate, issue a plan with dates, approve or decline rush, reassign resources	P1: 30 minutes; P2: 2 business hours; others: 1 business day

Tier	Escalation point	Triggers	Expected action	Time to act
Tier 3	Priya Venkataraman, Deputy Director, Customer Services	A P1 open more than 2 business hours without a documented plan; any ticket that has missed its resolution target twice; any escalation involving another GPO unit that has not responded in 1 business day	Convene the responsible units, set a resolution plan, communicate directly with the agency publishing officer	Same business day
Tier 4	Director, Customer Services (by Tier 3 referral only)	A P1 involving a Congressional deadline where the plan requires resources outside Customer Services	Authorize cross unit resources; brief agency leadership	Same business day

6.1 Escalation for specialist capability, not only for time

Some tickets need a specialist capability from the first minute. Route these directly, without waiting for a time trigger:

Need	Route to	Contact through
Section 508 checklist interpretation, remediation estimate, conformance report	Theo Lindqvist, Accessibility Specialist	Portal assignment; Teams
Digital file validation failure (RC-09), metadata questions, electronic release timing	Renee Castellanos, Digital Publishing Intake Coordinator	Portal assignment; Teams
Style question not answered by the Style Quick Reference	Harold Bemis, Editorial Standards Lead	Portal assignment (Style and editorial category)
Cost estimate dispute, rush approval, schedule change	Devin Okafor, Production Planning Lead	Portal assignment; telephone for P1
Liaison designation dispute, billing code authorization	Marisol Grant, Help Desk Supervisor	Portal assignment

7. After-Hours and Priority 1 Procedure

The help desk is not staffed outside 7:30 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. Eastern Time on business days. A customer who has a Priority 1 situation outside those hours follows this procedure.

1 Call the after-hours production line at (202) 555-0192. The line is answered by the production shift supervisor on duty. Quote your PSR number and state the deadline and its source (Congressional, statutory, or public commitment).

2 The shift supervisor records the call, assesses whether the job is physically in production, and takes any action available on the shift. The shift supervisor cannot approve new work, change specifications, or approve rush service.

3 Submit a ticket in the PHD Service Portal describing the situation and referencing the call. Select the Deadline risk category. The portal timestamps the ticket; the P1 clock starts at 7:30 a.m. on the next business day.

4 At 7:30 a.m. the help desk specialist on duty picks up all Deadline risk tickets first, notifies Tier 2 within 30 minutes, and sends the customer the P1 acknowledgment with the specialist's name and the update schedule.

5 Tier 2 issues a plan within 30 minutes of notification and updates the customer every 2 business hours until the ticket is resolved.

What the after-hours line is not

It is not a way to submit new work, to approve proofs, or to reach the help desk with routine questions. Calls that are not Priority 1 are logged and answered by the help desk on the next business day.

8. Substitute Roster

When a named escalation point is unavailable, the substitute below acts with the same authority. Substitutions are announced in the Publications Help Desk Teams channel each morning.

Role	Primary	Substitute	Second substitute
Help Desk Supervisor	Marisol Grant	Senior specialist on duty	Priya Venkataraman
Tier 2, Production Planning	Devin Okafor	Assistant Production Planner on duty	Production Manager
Tier 3, Deputy Director	Priya Venkataraman	Marisol Grant (acting)	Director, Customer Services
Accessibility Specialist	Theo Lindqvist	Renee Castellanos (structural checks only)	External remediation vendor for estimates
Digital Publishing Intake	Renee Castellanos	Theo Lindqvist	Help Desk Supervisor for intake logging only
Editorial Standards	Harold Bemis	Senior editor on duty	Help desk answers from the Style Quick Reference only

9. Service Reviews and Reporting

9.1 Monthly metrics

The help desk supervisor publishes the following metrics on the fifth business day of each month, covering the previous month. Metrics are published to the Customer Services leadership team and are available to agency publishing officers on request.

Metric	Definition	Target
First response attainment	Percentage of tickets with a first response within target, excluding clock stops	95 percent
Resolution attainment	Percentage of tickets resolved within target, excluding clock stops	90 percent
P1 plan within 30 minutes	Percentage of P1 tickets with a documented Tier 2 plan within 30 minutes of notification	100 percent
Returned PSR rate	Percentage of PSRs returned during completeness review	Below 15 percent
Median time to cost estimate	Business days from complete PSR to estimate issued	2 business days or less
Escalations per 100 tickets	Count of Tier 2 and Tier 3 escalations per 100 tickets	Trend only
Customer satisfaction	Average score on the closing survey, scale of 1 to 5	4.5 or higher

9.2 Quarterly service reviews

Each quarter the Deputy Director, Customer Services offers a service review to each agency with more than 20 tickets in the quarter. The review covers attainment against targets, recurring return reason codes for that agency, upcoming known deadlines, and any changes to this SLA. Reviews are 30 minutes and are scheduled through the agency publishing officer.

9.3 Continuous improvement

Every breach and every Tier 3 escalation is reviewed at the weekly help desk meeting. Where the cause is a gap in documentation, the relevant knowledge library document is updated and reissued with a new version number. Where the cause is capacity, the supervisor records it in the monthly report for leadership action.

10. Exceptions and Exclusions

- Targets are suspended during a declared GPO facility closure, a Government shutdown, or a declared emergency, and resume when normal operations resume. Tickets created during the suspension are prioritized on resumption.
- Targets do not apply to work performed by outside vendors. Production Planning communicates vendor schedules on the cost estimate.
- Delays caused by the customer, including late proof approvals, late file corrections, and unavailable approvers, are recorded as clock stops and are excluded from attainment.
- Requests that fall outside the scope of the help desk are handled as referrals and are subject only to the Referral targets.
- The SLA does not apply to security classified or Controlled Unclassified Information work, which is scheduled directly with Production Planning.

11. Disputes and Complaints

A customer who disagrees with a priority assignment asks the specialist for a review; the help desk supervisor decides and records the reason within 2 business hours for P1 and P2 requests and within 1 business day otherwise. A customer who is dissatisfied with the handling of a ticket may ask for the ticket to be reviewed by the Deputy Director, Customer Services, who responds within 2 business days. Complaints about individual staff members are handled through Customer Services management and are not discussed on the ticket.

12. Review and Revision

This SLA is reviewed every six months by the Deputy Director, Customer Services, with input from the help desk supervisor, the Production Planning Lead, and at least two agency publishing officers. Changes to targets, tiers, or contacts require a new version number. The current version is always the one posted in the Publications Help Desk knowledge library; printed copies are uncontrolled.

Appendix A: Escalation Contact Card

Tier or role	Name	How to reach	When
Help desk (Tier 1)	Specialist on duty	PHD Service Portal; pubhelpdesk@gpo.gov; (202) 555-0147	Staffed hours
Tier 2	Devin Okafor, Production Planning Lead	Portal escalation; (202) 555-0163 for P1	Staffed hours
Tier 3	Priya Venkataraman, Deputy Director, Customer Services	Portal escalation via Tier 2; (202) 555-0178	Staffed hours
After-hours production line	Shift supervisor on duty	(202) 555-0192	Outside staffed hours, P1 only
Accessibility	Theo Lindqvist	Portal assignment; Teams	Staffed hours
Digital publishing intake	Renee Castellanos	Portal assignment; Teams	Staffed hours
Editorial standards	Harold Bemis	Portal, Style and editorial category	Staffed hours
Help desk supervisor	Marisol Grant	Portal; (202) 555-0151	Staffed hours

Appendix B: Escalation Note Template

Specialists use this template when escalating a ticket. A complete note lets the escalation point act without a second conversation.

Field	What to write
Ticket and PSR	PHD-YYYY-NNNNNN; PSR-YY-NNNNN
Priority and reason	P1, Congressional hearing print due [date]
Customer	Name, agency, telephone, and whether the agency publishing officer is aware
What is blocked	One sentence describing the stuck step
What has been tried	Actions taken at Tier 1 and the result of each
What is needed	The specific decision or action requested from the escalation point
Deadline	The date and time by which the action is needed, and what happens if it is missed
Next customer update due	Date and time from the priority cadence

Appendix C: Worked Example

A liaison at a customer agency calls at 4:40 p.m. on a Thursday to report that a 5,000 copy booklet due at a public event on Monday has not shipped and the portal shows In Production. The specialist creates a ticket in the Deadline risk category, assigns P1 because a public commitment date is at risk, sends the P1 acknowledgment, and notifies Tier 2 at 4:47 p.m. Tier 2 confirms with the finishing supervisor that the job is in the bindery and will ship Friday by expedited carrier at no additional charge because the delay was internal. Tier 2 records the plan on the ticket at 5:05 p.m. The specialist updates the customer at 5:10 p.m. and again at 9:30 a.m. Friday with the tracking number. The ticket is resolved at 9:35 a.m. Friday, within the 4 business hour target once staffed hours are counted (20 minutes Thursday, 2 hours 5 minutes Friday).